

A Guide to Open Source Desktop Project Management Tools



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Is the high cost of commercial project management software holding back your team from gaining valuable skills to take on larger projects? Open source can help. This article is the start of a series on open source project management tools.

A project is kicked off to accomplish a specific goal, which is different from the usual day-to-day operations of a business. For example, if you have a factory, your production work happens every day. However, if you want to add an extension to your factory, you can manage it as a project. Your team may require different skills for this, and so you may have to co-opt from other teams or sub-contractors to complete the project. Every project should have a well-defined purpose or end goal. It should also have a clearly defined beginning and end.

People don't plan to fail, they just fail to plan

This will become more obvious with a practical example. Let us say that your sales are increasing and you have ordered a new machine for your factory. Without advance planning, after the machine arrives, you may realise that it takes at least a week for the concrete foundation on which it has to be placed to set. You will lose the opportunity to use the new machine and satisfy your customers as well as increase your sales. If you had done some planning, you would have realised that the foundation should be ready before the

machine arrives. You could have asked the machine manufacturer to send you the foundation drawing in advance. This would have helped prepare the foundation with bolts placed to match the holes in the base of the machine well before it arrived.

On time and under budget

To be 'on time' and 'under budget' are the two key factors for a project's success — everything else is secondary. Even among these two, when the schedule slips, project costs tend to go up because more time means more work. So, first and foremost, we want a